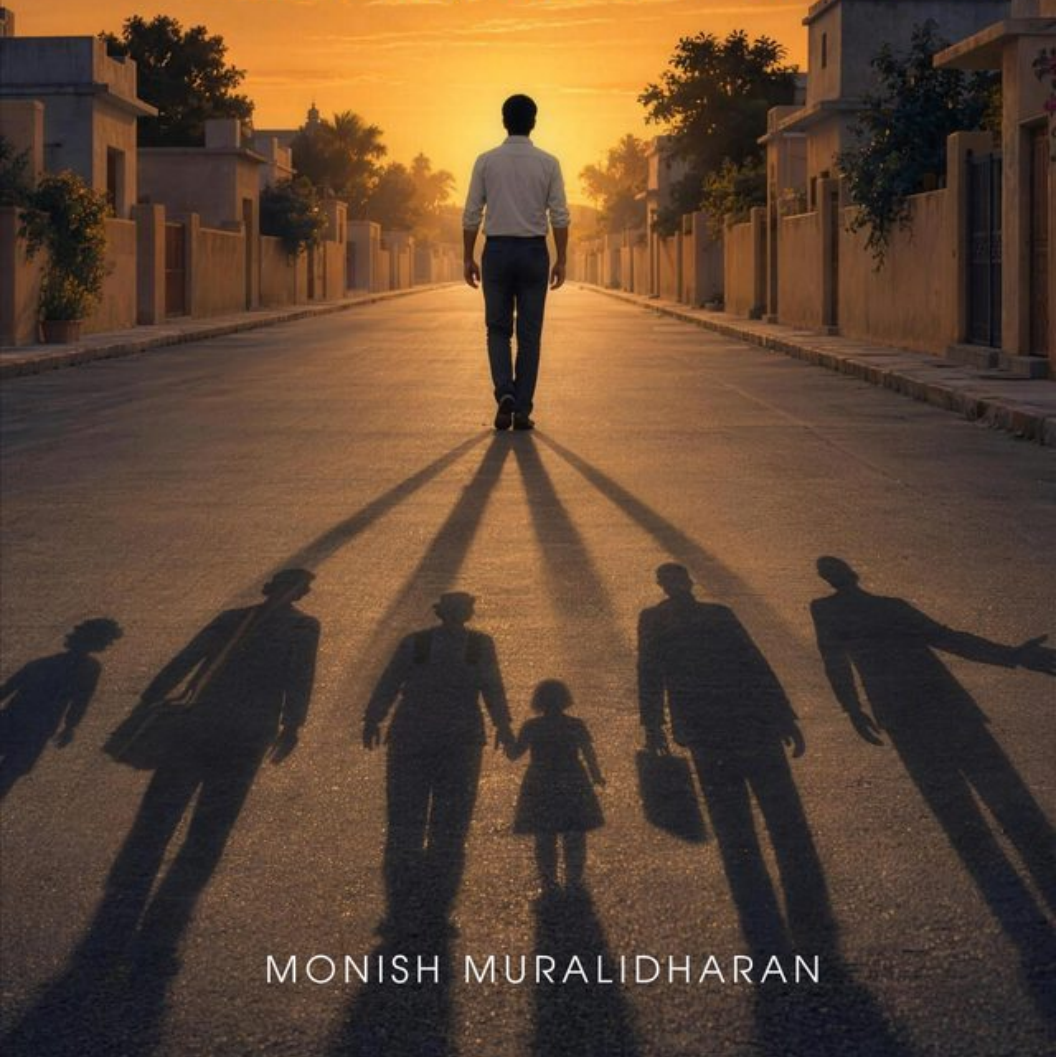


MODERN DAY MEN

There is always a better life for men



MONISH MURALIDHARAN

Modern Day Men

The Prologue

Monish Muralidharan

Chennai

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This excerpt discusses dark hours. It never describes how a life ends,
only how one continues. If it finds you on a heavy night, these
India-based lines are open all night:

Tele-MANAS (Govt. of India) 14416 or 1800-891-4416, free, 24x7

Vandrevala Foundation +91 9999 666 555, call or WhatsApp, 24x7

AASRA +91-22-27546669, 24 hours

In immediate danger, call 112.

Prologue: 2:47 AM

2:47 AM. A rented house, a thousand kilometres from the town I still call home.

The fridge hums. That is the whole sound of the house.

I am at the dining table with a laptop, a headset, and tea that went cold around midnight. On the screen, a chat window and a list of client tasks. My client is on the other side of the planet. For him it is afternoon.

A message pops up.

Great work today. You're a lifesaver.

I look at that word for a while.

Somewhere across the world, a man I have never met thinks I have my life together.

The bedroom door is closed. My wife is asleep behind it. We had a storm today. I will not tell you what it was about, because by that point it was never really about anything. A cup. A desk. A sentence said in the wrong tone.

My son is asleep in the other room, one arm thrown over his face, the way he sleeps when the day was too big for him.

The day was too big for me too.

I ate dinner at eleven, standing near the kitchen sink. Then I finished four more client tasks. I typed “no problem at all” to a stranger in another country while my chest carried a weight I

had stopped mentioning to anyone.

Nobody tells you about this hour. The work ends. The screen goes quiet. And there is nothing left between you and your own head.

The questions come in order. They always come in order.

Is it like this for everyone?

Why can't I fix this? I spend all day fixing things for other people.

Am I the bad guy here?

When did I last talk to my brother? Really talk, not the birthday call.

Shouldn't men be happy?

And under all of them, in the dark below the dark, a quieter thought. That night I understood how a man can be surrounded by people who love him and still want to disappear. I will not describe that thought any further. If you know it, you know it. If you don't, I am glad, and I hope you never do.

Here is what I did instead. It is the only reason this book exists.

At 3:10 AM, I opened a browser. Not for the client. For myself. I started typing a question I was too ashamed to ask any living person.

is it normal for a married man to feel

The search box finished my sentence before I could.

Trapped. Alone. Invisible. Like a failure. Like leaving.

A search box offers you the words other people have already typed. Somebody had typed mine. Seeing those words made me feel less alone.

I sat back. The fridge hummed. Something in my chest loosened, maybe a centimetre.

I read strangers till the sky went grey. Different cities, different jobs, the same hour. Again and again, the same sentence in different words: *I have never told anyone this.*

Near dawn I closed the laptop and made myself one small promise. I am still keeping it. You are holding it.

Let me tell you plainly what this book is, so you don't waste your money.

I am not a doctor or a guru. There are no ten steps here, no morning routine, no mantra. Men get enough instructions. Bring the salary. Hold the family. Fix the tap. Don't cry. I have nothing to add to that list.

I am only going to tell you what happened. To me, and to men like us. The boy who was taught big boys don't cry. The son whose first salary was spent before it arrived. The man on night shifts, living against the sun. The husband walking on eggshells in his own house. The father doing midnight maths with his child's face in the answer. The man who broke. The man who came back, and how.

Some of them started with nothing and some had everything, and the night they each sat through is the same night. Yours.

It is built for tired men. Short chapters, small pieces in between, readable anywhere, in any order.

And if it is 2:47 AM where you are right now, I want you to know one thing.

You are not the only man awake. You never were.

If tonight is heavy, don't carry it alone. One call is enough to start: Tele-MANAS (Govt. of India): 14416 or 1800-891-4416 within India, free, 24x7 · Vandrevalla Foundation: +91 9999 666 555, call or WhatsApp, free counselling, 24x7 · AASRA: +91-22-27546669, 24 hours. These numbers are not only for emergencies. They are for men like us, on nights like this.

If you're reading this at 3 AM, I wrote it at 3 AM.

Same chair. Same silence. Same weight.

Keep reading. We're awake together now.

This is the Prologue of *Modern Day Men* by Monish Muralidharan. Nineteen chapters follow it. When the book opens for pre-order, you will hear first.

moderndaymen.in

For the men who were awake at 2:47, and for the ones who stayed.